A Story About a Bomb

By Jonathan Tel

INTRODUCTION

A story about a bomb is not a bomb. However artfully constructed the plot, however incendiary the theme, although the topic may be volatile and the implications explosive, however dangerous the sentiments may be – a story will not in fact abolish itself in a blinding flash, scattering shrapnel within a radius of forty meters and shredding passersby. Despite our best efforts. A Story About a Bomb by Jonathan Tel

Several years ago I browsed through an anthology of Palestinian literature. There was one story that struck me as remarkable at the time; and that has stayed with me since, burning in my memory. Its title was *The Red Button.*

It concerned a Hamas terrorist (or freedom fighter, if you prefer) who was on the point of blowing himself up, along with as many Israelis as possible. He was shifting from leg to leg in Jerusalem, near where

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the new city meets the old, across from Jaffa Gate, on the wrong side of the highway.

It was eight o'clock in the morning on the hottest Friday in August. He had come from a refugee camp in Gaza, and had spent the previous night praying with some comrades near Bethlehem. He had just been dropped off by Toyota. He was wearing a long padded overcoat, buttoned up, to conceal the bands of dynamite around his abdomen. He was sweating and shivering. His instructions were to cross the road (looking carefully to right and to left first; it wouldn't do to be knocked down by a speeding vehicle before he had a chance to press the button on the detonator) to the bus stop on the far side. With any luck, there would e many Israelis waiting there. He would simply have to stand among them, mutter *Allahu Akbar*, and the next thing he knew he would be marching into Paradise, a pair of dark-eyed houris eager to kiss his bleeding wounds. In reality, of course, it was not as simple as all that.

Every bone in his body ached. (He had had to crouch on the back floor of the Toyota, concealed under

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a carpet, for what had seemed like generations.) He smelled his own sweat. The bus stop in question was within view. He could see would-be passengers waiting there, more or less patiently. Women, children, old men, also about ten soldiers, perhaps on weekend leave. The ideal target. Yet he had to wait. The traffic was atrocious. He stepped into the road – and a great red Coca Cola truck went roaring past. A Subaru blurted its horn at him. A police car swept by. He hobbled back to the safety of the curb. Finally the road was empty. On the far side, a Number 23 was halted at the stop . . . By the time he arrived there, the bus had departed, taking all the Israelis with it. If he reached into his pocket and jabbed down on the button now, he would explode nobody but himself. He could have wept with frustration.

He kept the vision of Paradise clear in front of him. As it is written: " . . . *that Allah may know those who believe, and take martyrs from among you* . . . " Two houris would come dancing toward him. They would cloak him in the precious *hulla* robe. They would say, "*May*

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Allah put dust on the face of those who put dust on your face!" . . . An acrid aroma; a clammy feeling around the groin. He had got beyond the trembling stage. He was on an exalted level of anguish. Now the twitching was intense, as if he were being banged like a saltcellar on a humid day.

Now at last the future seemed revealed. Now a fresh selection of Israelis had appeared at the stop. Now there was a hiatus in the traffic – no vehicles to delay him, no bus to carry away his victims. And then, just as he was about to scurry across the expanse of asphalt, to leap forward into his destiny, to switch on the detonator . . .

A middle-aged couple approached the terrorist. They stood beside the curb, blocking his way. The man had thin sandy hair whirled over a bald spot. He was wearing baggy green shorts. An oversize map was sprouting from his shirt pocket. He was waving his yellow Holyland Tours baseball cap to attract the terrorist's attention. The woman, blonde, had on an identical cap; she was also in shorts, blue ones, matching

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her varicose veins. The two of them were addressing him in what he reasonably believed to be English

Since he evidently did not understand, the tourists resorted to sign language. The man was holding up a camera – it was suspended from a strap around his neck – he was hoisting it free. The woman was pointing to it. Much dumbshow ensured, involving grasping and lifting the Olympus, gesturing at elements of it (automatic focus; you just have to aim the thing and shoot), peering through the viewfinder, and going *cheese* . . . (And all the while, Hativat Yerushalayim remaind free of traffic, the ignorant Israelis were unmoving – how simple and easy to blow them and himself up, the exemplary conclusion – if only those damn foreigners would just get out of his way!)

But what could he do? If he tried to escape from them, let alone grapple with them, he would only draw attention to himself. The Israelis would just run off, or one of them might draw a gun and kill him before he'd be able to complete his mission. No, the only hope

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was to go through with what the foreigners wanted, and then they would leave him in peace.

The tourists posed on the curbside. The husband put his arm around his wife's shoulder. They smiled as if they were genuinely happy. As if purely to be in Jerusalem was to be blessed. The terrorist stepped back, arranging their faces within the rectangle of the viewfinder. He motioned the couple with his left hand, to lean their heads closer together; to step a little this way – so he could catch them with Jaffa Gate behind, for extra picturesqueness . . . Somehow, miraculously, as he squinted through the viewfinder, all his quavering and uncertainties had ceased. He was aware of nothing except this instant. As for the tourists, they would look at the snapshot and remember their trip to the Holy Land for the rest of their lives . . . Ah, perfect now. The tip of an index finger pressed down on a red button – and the story ended.

Of course my summary of the story doesn't capture the magic of the original. How could it? The author, Ahmed Fishawi took great pains to bring us

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inside the mind and body of the central character. What exactly was the author, this Mr. Fishawi, trying to say? Was he drawing an analogy between terrorist and tourist? Furthermore, as the years have gone by, I have come to wonder: Perhaps the author was too good a writer. He has taken us too much inside the mind of a terrorist. If we are brought to – more than understand – to sympathize with the terrorist, then are we not, in some sense, colluding with him?

The other day I was at a party in Tel Aviv. As usual in Israel, the guests were arguing about politics. I did yearn for meatier conversation . . . . [when] I noticed a man standing by himself to one side, saying nothing. I introduced myself. "What do you think of all this? I asked him.

"What do they know? The only Arabs they ever see are the guys who pick up their garbage. Believe you me, 99% of the Palestinians support Hamas – whether they admit it or not. The only way we'll have peace is if the Arabs know there's a gun pointing at their head."

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"That's an interesting point of view," An then, I alluded to *The Red Button*.

"I know that piece. Yes, I . . . I know it very well. As a matter of fact – I am Ahmed Fishawi. And by the way, don't keep calling it 'fiction'. Fiction schmiction! The Red Button is true, every word of it. The events describe took place on the morning of August 8th 1999. I know because I was there. Do you want to know what actually happened? I was there. I was leaning against a lamppost. On the other side of the terrorist, a couple of lovers were kissing . . . So the terrorist pressed the red button on the camera . . . At that moment – when we knew for sure he wouldn't have a free hand to operate the detonator – I came running up from behind and I slammed into his back. The 'lovers' seized his arms between them. And the male 'tourist' put on the handcuffs while the female 'tourist' kicked him. I'm in counter-terrorism – Shimshon Unit. Have you heard of us? We'd been following the poor *guy* ever since he left Gaza. We eliminated his entire cell. I almost killed myself! And everybody else too! See, when I ran into

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him, somehow the detonator started up. By a miracle it didn't set the bomb off. So all that happened was that the *terrorist* got third degree burns on his belly and I screwed up my arm."

He rolled up his right sleeve. Just above the wrist, a patch of skin was distorted, thickly ridged—as if the flesh had melted like wax and refrozen.

"So then we took him back to HQ. We put him in the medical unit for a while – Intensive Care – until we knew he wasn't going to die on us, and he was out of pain. Then we could torture him. Don't look so shocked. We call it torture but it's not what you think of as torture; it's the gentle art of persuasion. We use the official methods—making him sit in one position for hours, in a child-size chair – shaking him till he rattles. It's toughies like me who stop the Arabs from blowing up the kindergartens! Of course we didn't have to torture him, hardly at all. Not in his case. He knew he'd be spending years in an Israeli prison, instead of partying with houris in Paradise. He didn't want to be alive. We stood beside the hospital bed, and we shouted at him. SO he told us

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the names and addresses. Everything we wanted to know. Who his commander was, the location of his safe house. And then we locked him up, and that was the end of that.

"I think you underestimate yourself," I said. "you say you're not a fiction writer – and maybe the outline of your story is based on truth – but how on earth did you get inside the man's head? Those interior monologues. I can't believe this is your first story!"

"I asked the *guy* to help me. That's how I know. Not too bad a fellow, the terrorist, once you get to be friends with him. I played the nice guy. I said, if you tell me every little thing that went through your head, I'll let you read the Quran, and I'll give you the cutest little prayer mat to keep you company . . . And then when he'd told me everything he could think of, I used the other method to job his memory."

"What other method?" I said.

I literally felt the hairs stand up on my neck – a sensation I'd only ever read about in books, that I'd always supposed to be fictional.

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"The usual. What a man like you would call background research. I wend town to his cell and I tied a blanket soaked in *urine* over his head. Then I patted him in the kidneys with the butt of my rifle . . . It took 72 hours before he broke. He answered all my questions. I don't need to tell you what he said. Every little detail, and more besides. His childhood. His grandmother. His uncle. His religious beliefs. What he felt and what he smelled. And it was worth it. A chance in a lifetime. *The Red Button's* a great story. You told me so yourself. . . "

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